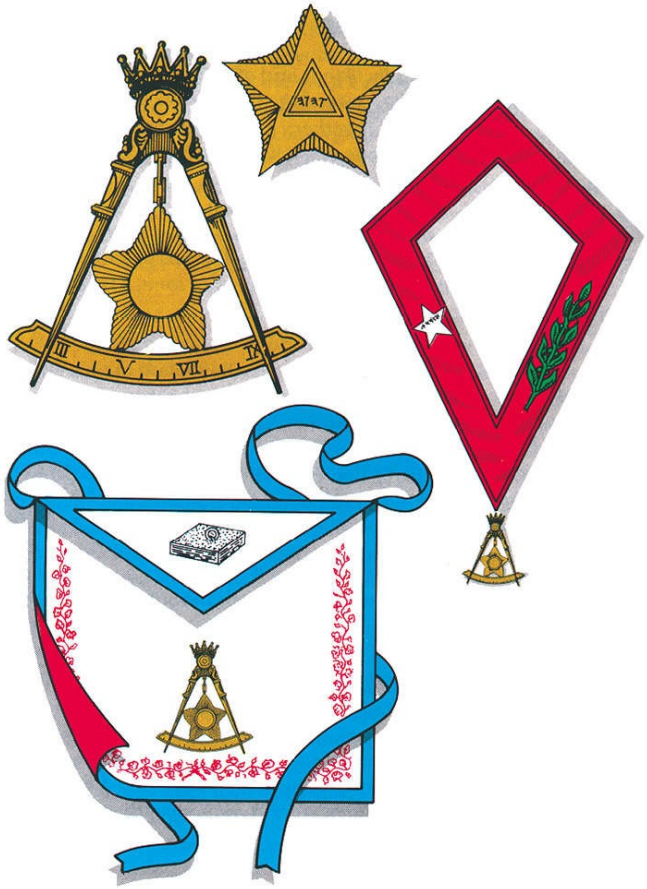
The 14th Degree – Perfect Elu



The apron is of white lambskin, lined with crimson and edged with blue. Around it, on the inside of the blue edging is a delicate embroidery in crimson representing a wreath of flowers. In the middle of the apron is painted or embroidered the jewel, and on the flap is a representation of a flat square stone to which is attached a ring, representing the entrance to the secret vault of the preceding degree. Of its three colors, white, like the snowy purity of the ermine, represents justice; blue, the color of the perfectly symmetrical and changeless arch of the sky, represents right; and crimson, the color of fire which tries and purifies all things, represents truth.

The cordon is a collar of crimson velvet, worn over the neck and coming to a point on the breast. On the left side is embroidered, in green, a branch of acacia, symbolizing immortality. On the right is embroidered, in silver, a five–pointed star, with a Phoenician word meaning “perfection” in the center. The five–

pointed star, as a type of all stars, is representative of Masonic light. The five points also stand for the five points of fellowship and remind us of the other interpretations of this number given in the lecture of the 2nd Degree of the Symbolic Lodge.

The jewel is a pair of compasses, opened upon a quarter of a circle, and surmounted by a pointed crown. Within the compasses is a medal, representing on one side the sun, and on the other a five–pointed star, in the center of which is a delta, and on that the name of Deity in Phoenician characters. This jewel is gold and worn suspended from the collar. On the segment of the circle are enameled, at proper distances from each other, the numerals III...V...VII...IX. The compasses remind us that science, united to honor and virtue, made the architect of the Temple the companion of kings; and that the men of intellect and learning, the great kings of thought, are in this age the rulers of the world. The sun as the source of light to our system was once worshiped as a god. The star as a type of the myriad suns that light other countless systems of worlds is an emblem of that Masonic Light in search of which every Mason travels—the correct knowledge of the Deity, and of His laws that control the universe.

The brethren of this degree also wear white gloves, symbolic of purity.

DUTIES

Assist, encourage and defend the brethren.
Protect the oppressed and relieve want and distress. Enlighten the people.
Serve the common good and be fruitful of all good works.

LESSONS

Perfect Elus are both bound and free: bound by their obligation and free from prejudice, intolerance and envy.
Masons meet on the level because in their lives authority and liberty are in equilibrium.

FOR REFLECTION

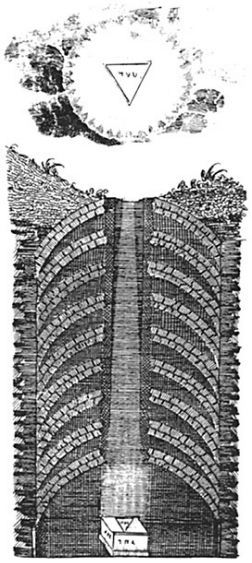
If perfection is not attainable, for what does the Mason strive?

IMPORTANT SYMBOLS

Baptism, horizontal passageway to the vault, the cube, Seal of Solomon, columns, triangular pedestal, Great Candelabrum with 7 lights.

This degree is styled the Degree of Perfection because it represents the perfection or completion of the degrees of the Scottish Rite Symbolic Lodge. Mackey identifies it as having a history of France, tying it to certain groups who desired the restoration of the Stuart dynasty to the throne of England. The degree has been rewritten to remove the blatant political motives, replacing those lessons with ones of a frankly more religious and philosophical character.

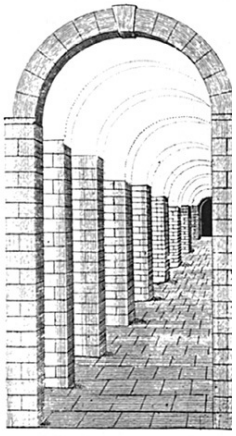
This degree and the 13th are very closely related. The legend associated with the cubical stone bearing the Ineffable Name of Deity discovered and taken to King Solomon in the 13th Degree is continued here. Solomon decides to place the cubical stone in a special underground vault used by himself, King Hiram of Tyre and the Master Hiram for private conferences. The contrast between the crypt of Enoch and that of Solomon form an important part of the allegory of this and the 13th Degree.



Enoch's Crypt
From Jeremy Cross

These crypts, one built by Enoch and the other by Solomon, have two important symbolic interpretations. The first is that the crypts are "inward"

symbols; that is, being hidden under the earth they direct us to focus our reflections upon the inward qualities of man, a reminder of the Symbolic Lodge instruction that it is the internal, and not the external, qualifications that recommend a man to be made a Mason. The second is that these crypts were built in a very different fashion and must be seen as distinct, yet united, symbols: distinct because each has its own meaning and united because together they form an entirely different symbol with its own interpretation. The crypt of Enoch was built vertically. The vertical direction is symbolic of the spiritual dimension of the universe. Enoch receives a prophetic vision directing him to build his crypt and deposit the sacred treasure therein. Following the completion of this spiritual task Enoch does not suffer death but is taken directly to heaven (Genesis 5:24). The crypt of Enoch is discovered and the treasure is removed and taken to Solomon who now deposits it in the innermost chamber of his crypt, constructed horizontally between his most retired apartment and the Sanctum Sanctorum of the Temple. The horizontal direction signifies earthly things. Solomon was not a spiritual leader; his wisdom was the wisdom of the earth – he was a wise and just ruler of men, but less so of himself. He began to worship strange gods and led a majority of his people into idolatry with him. Thus were the Hebrew people punished by their conquest and captivity in Babylonia– a story which will occupy our attention during the next two degrees.



Solomon's Crypt
From Jeremy Cross

Uniting the vertical with the horizontal creates the symbol of the cross. All the world's messiahs have sought to unify the spiritual and earthly qualities of man, providing a model of perfection. This is the perfection taught in Masonry: living this life to the fullest while preparing for the next. In the 18th Degree this lesson will itself be brought to completion.

CEREMONY

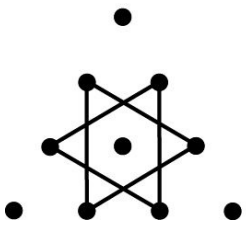
The Lodge here represents the innermost chamber of the secret vault or crypt of King Solomon's Temple in which the True Word, lost in the legend of the Master's degree, is revealed and allowed to be pronounced. The vault is approached by a horizontal passageway with nine arches. The arch figures prominently in this degree. It is a symbol used in many of the advanced rites of Masonry. Its importance is presumed to derive from a custom of operative Masons; they marked each stone of a building which served to identify the workman who had placed and adjusted the stone. When an arch contains a keystone, it is placed in the center of the arch and holds the other stones in their places, assuring stability to the arch. The most prominent mark of the operative Masons on the stones of the arch appeared on the keystone. This mark was made by the superintendent of the building. The ancient Hebrews did not, in fact, use the keystone; it being of Roman origin. It is therefore to be understood as symbolic only, signifying stability and permanence.

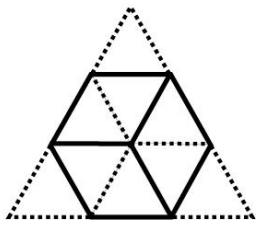
While the passageway with nine arches is guarded by three sentinels and dimly lit, the Lodge is brilliant and resplendent with light. The colors gold and white predominate in the set and reflect the light from the numerous sources within the room: the lighted pedestal upon which is the cube of agate bearing the Ineffable Name, the three lights in the South forming an equilateral triangle, the five in the West making a square with one light in the center, the seven also in the West forming a square enclosing a triangle. In the East nine lights form a triple triangle, and the Great Candelabrum on the Altar of Obligation contains seven lights, as in the 4th Degree, but arranged differently.

The Altar of Obligation is covered with a white cloth fringed in gold; embroidered upon it in gold, on the east side, are the Phoenician characters for the Hebrew word meaning “perfection.” The Table of Incense is of white wood embellished with gold. The Table of the Bread of the Presence is of white wood trimmed in gold.

The hangings are crimson with white columns painted on them at intervals. The lecture for this degree, provides us with the information to understand the symbolic meaning of the columns, “Whatever the number of the pillars [in ancient temples], they were mystical everywhere” (p. 235). The meaning, of course, varied with the temple and the religious beliefs of those who erected it. The columns may have been astrological or could have recorded the advent of seasons or may have represented the number of days or months in a year. In all cases, however, it is significant that they were there as a testament to the sacred character of the edifice. Thus we may see their presence in the Scottish Rite degrees as a reminder of the sacred character of the teachings of Masonry. They also remind us of the presence of the Deity in places other than temples such as the secret vault which is represented by the Lodge.

An important symbol here is the Seal of Solomon, formed by two interlaced triangles, one white and the other black. It was first seen in the 12th Degree. This six pointed star can be found hidden within the Pythagorean Tetractys. Among the Greeks the hexad (or number 6) was considered a symbol of marriage and the figure drawn from the six dots which circle the central dot of the Tetractys thus form an apt symbol of this number as it creates six smaller equilateral triangles, the children of the union of the two large triangles. There are deeper and more significant meanings which are to be revealed in later degrees.





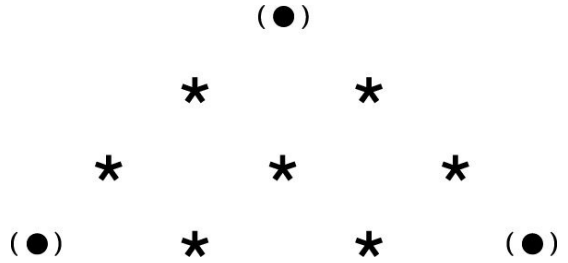
The cube, a profound symbol of many diverse meanings, is first found in the 13th Degree as a symbol of the Scottish Rite. Of course, it is seen in the 1st

Degree of the Symbolic Lodge where, as is appropriate, it is given a simple interpretation. There the cube is called the perfect ashlar and stands as a symbol of the union between operative and speculative Masonry. As one of the five so–called Platonic solids (which some have attributed to Pythagoras), the cube's adoption as a mystical symbol was inevitable. It is six–sided and formed of perfect squares; at most only three sides are visible from any perspective and, like the Seal of Solomon, it nestles within the Tetractys as an optical illusion. These qualities combined to give the numerologically inclined ancients much opportunity for reflection and speculation. The lighted pedestal is triangular so that the light emanating therefrom may be seen as representing light from the Deity. It should only be necessary to remind that the name of Deity as the source of light both figuratively and literally lights the lodge. Pike tells us:

> *Let every Grand Elect, Perfect, and Sublime Mason cherish this faith. It is a duty. It is the brilliant and never–dying light that shines within and through the symbolic pedestal of alabaster, on which reposes the perfect cube of agate, symbol of duty, inscribed with the divine name of God* (p. 231).

The word reveal means to "re–veil," that is, to give one explanation and yet continue to maintain the mystery of the symbol by not explaining it in a full and complete manner. Just how this is accomplished may be illustrated by an examination of the lights of the Great Candelabrum, both their number and arrangement. Below is a diagram showing how the lights are to be arranged, illustrating, Pike says, the seven planets known to the ancients: the sun (in the center), moon, Mercury, Venus, Mars, Jupiter and Saturn. That this is not the only meaning of the lights may readily be seen, by the fact that there are no particular assignments of lights with planets. The assignment of the sun as the central light is the reveiling of the symbolism as we are led to see the other six lights arranged around the central one as the planets are around the sun. This concept the ancients did not even possess. The "lights" in parentheses are not in the arrangement and are added here to show the essential form of the Pythagorean Tetractys guiding the placement of the lights in the Lodge which

emphasize that portion of the Pythagorean Tetractys that creates the optical illusion of a perfect cube within its bounds; appropriately the cube is a principle symbol in this degree.



The candidate again represents Yehu–Aber, as in the 8th Degree, and is symbolically aspiring to the qualities of fortitude and heroism by the practice of charity, benevolence, virtue, self–improvement and the correction of the faults of his brethren. He enters into the dimly lit and guarded passageway clothed as a Master Architect. Upon his reception into the brilliant splendor of the lodge room, he must provide assurances to the brethren of his worthiness to receive the Degree of Perfection and thereby learn the pronunciation of the Sacred Word, binding himself more firmly to the Masonic brotherhood.

Several degrees in the various Rites of Masonry require the candidates to spend a little time in quiet and solitude that they may reflect upon their character and the seriousness of the obligations they are about to take. In this degree searching questions are posed to the candidate. He is sent to the Chamber of Reflection while the brethren consider his fitness to be received into the Order. Darkness is not a new condition to the Mason who has advanced to this degree. Mackey relates, “In the Ancient Mysteries, the aspirant was always shrouded in darkness as a preparatory step to the reception of the full light of knowledge” (Vol. 1, p. 262). The period of darkness varied with the particular mysteries; among the Druids it was reputed to be nine days and nights, in the Grecian Mysteries twenty–seven days and among the Persians fifty days. The periods of darkness in Masonry are shortened considerably and symbolize a state of preparation, of non–existence before birth and of ignorance before the reception of knowledge.

Few religious ceremonies have both the universality and antiquity of ritual purification by water. Whether called “lustration,” as Mackey suggests, or the more common “baptism,” this custom forms an essential part of several degrees in both the Scottish and York Rites. It is not, as is often supposed, to be considered a borrowing of the Christian practice of baptism but rather should be understood as the continuation of a ceremony far older than John the Baptist. As Pike has noted, it was practiced in ancient times by Hindus, Chaldeans, Egyptians, Etruscans and at the greater mystery ceremonies of Greece. Some have seen the flood described in the Bible as a baptism of the entire earth. In addition, there are many literal and metaphorical passages in the Old Testament alluding to this practice in various forms. Certainly it could not be said that John was practicing Christian baptism as that faith did not even exist when he was practicing his craft at the Jordan River.

Having been purified symbolically by baptism and having fulfilled the necessary conditions and requirements, the candidate is initiated a Grand Elect, Perfect and Sublime Mason. In an act reminiscent of the ancient Hebrew, Indian and Persian sacrifice of bread and wine, the brethren partake of the bread and wine from the Table of the Bread of the Presence. The Bread itself, according to Mackey, is a symbol of “the eternal life by which we are brought into the presence of God and know Him” (Vol. 2, p. 934); the wine represents “the inward refreshment of a good conscience ... [and] should remind us of the eternal refreshments which the good are to receive in the future life for the faithful performance of duty in the present” (Vol. 2, p. 1110). The ceremonial sharing of bread and wine are a symbol of the perfection of the candidate, of his bond with the Masonic fraternity and of the secrecy demanded from the Perfect Elu.

Along with the apron, cordon and jewel, the candidate also becomes eligible to receive the 14th Degree ring. Pike attributes the origin of this gift to a similar votive given to the candidate passing through the Gothic Mysteries where it represented divine protection (pp. 430–431). The motto inscribed in Latin within its boundaries translates to: “Virtue has united, and death shall not separate” (*virtus junxit mors non separabit*). The ring symbolizes the immutable and

eternal nature of Masonic virtues and the brotherhood they inspire. It is equally worthwhile to reflect on the ring as denoting power (or authority) and affection. When Pharaoh made Joseph ruler over all Egypt he presented him with his ring, probably a sort of signet, representing his authority which was being transferred to, or at least shared with, Joseph (see Genesis 41:42). The ring as a symbol of the marriage vow leads one to reflect on the covenant of the Mason and the Fraternity. Small wonder that as a candidate you were encouraged to wear it and to bequeath it to your closest relative or friend, who should keep and treasure, but not wear, it.

LECTURE

The lecture in *Morals and Dogma* and the instruction in the ceremony have two major purposes: one, to encourage reflection on the nature of Deity and man's relationship with Him; and two, to review the duties taught in all the Ineffable Degrees.

The Nature of Deity and Man's Relationship to Him:

1. The Mason does not pretend to dogmatic certainty, nor vainly imagine such certainty attainable.
2. As to our feelings toward God and our conduct toward man, Masonry teaches little about which men can differ, and little from which they can dissent.
3. Man's views in regard to God will contain only so much positive truth as the human mind is capable of receiving.
4. Every man's conception of God must vary with his mental cultivation and mental powers.
5. God is the great source of all life and matter.
6. The Mason regards God as a Moral Governor, as well as an Original Creator.
7. The Mason believes that God has arranged this glorious but perplexing world with a purpose and on a plan.

8. God created and governs this world by fixed, unwavering and inexorable laws.
9. God takes a watchful and presiding interest in the affairs of the world and influences the thoughts and actions of men.
10. God is our Father in Heaven, in whose constant presence we live and act.
11. Every man sent into this world possesses some portion of God's Truth which he must proclaim.
12. The Perfect Elu should ever labor to elevate and purify his motives.
13. The Perfect Elu should not be indifferent to the fate of his own soul.

Duties:

In the 14th Degree the candidate recites the duties taught him in the previous Degrees:

- **4th**: P*ractice silence, obedience, fidelity*
- **5th:** *Cultivate honesty, sincerity, good faith*
- **6th:** *Be zealous, faithful, disinterested & benevolent; act the peacemaker*
- **7th:** *Decide justly, impartially; do justice to all men*
- **8th:** *Inculcate benevolence and charity; brotherly sympathy for those in one's employ*
- **9th:** *Destroy ignorance*
- **10th:** *Contend against tyranny and fanaticism*
- **11th:** B*e earnest, true, reliable; be the advocate and champion of the rights of the people*
- **12th:** *Seek truth and right*
- **13th:** *Be guided and directed by honor and duty*
- **14th:** *Be devoted to virtue and the cause of humanity*

4th Degree:

Perhaps few of those who have ever labored, in the patience of secrecy and silence, to bring about some political or social change, which they felt convinced would ultimately prove of vast service to humanity, lived to see the change effected, or the anticipated good flow from it (p. 230).

5th Degree:

[A good Mason is one who] can look upon death, and see its face with the same countenance with which he hears its story; ... (p. 219).

6th Degree:

[A good Mason is one who] *can equally despise riches when he hath them and when he hath them not; ... that can look upon another man's lands with equanimity and pleasure, as if they were his own; ...* (pp. 219–220).

[Masonry] *is philanthropic; for it recognizes the great truth that all men are of the same origin, have common interests, and should co–operate together to the same end* (p. 221).

The hope of success, and not the hope of reward, should be our stimulating and sustaining power. Our object, and not ourselves, should be our inspiring thought (p. 229).

7th Degree:

The true Mason, sincerely holding that a Supreme God created and governs this world, believes also that He governs it by laws, which though wise, just and beneficent, are yet steady, unwavering, inexorable (p. 228).

8th Degree:

The true Mason ... believes that his agonies and sorrows are ordained for his chastening, his strengthening, his elaboration and development... (p. 228).

He who industriously sows and reaps is a good laborer, and worthy of his hire. But he who sows that which shall be reaped by others, by those who will know not of and care not for the sower, is a laborer of a nobler order, and, worthy of a more excellent reward (p. 231).

9th & 10th Degrees:

[Masonry] *is the Hercules, the Osiris, the Apollo, the Mithras, and the Ormuzd, at everlasting and deadly feud with the demons of ignorance, brutality, baseness, falsehood, slavishness of soul, intolerance, superstition, tyranny, meanness, the insolence of wealth, and bigotry* (p. 221).

9th & 12th Degrees:

Essentially philanthropic, philosophical, and progressive, [Masonry] *has for the basis of its dogma a firm belief in the existence of God and his providence, and of the immortality of the soul; for its object, the dissemination of moral, political, philosophical and religious truth, and the practice of all virtues* (p. 220).

11th Degree:

Life is real, and is earnest, and it is full of duties to be performed. It is the beginning of our immortality. Those only who feel a deep interest and affection for this world will work resolutely for its amelioration... (p. 231) .

12th Degree:

... to do that which it is right to do, not because it will insure you success, or bring with it a reward, or gain the applause of men, or be the "best policy," more prudent or more advisable; but because it is right, and therefore ought to be done... (p. 219).

13th Degree:

To make honor and duty the steady beacon–lights that shall guide your life–vessel over the stormy seas of time... (p. 219).

14th Degree:

And such a Mason may reckon his life to be the life of a man, and compute his months, not by the course of the sun, but by the zodiac and circle of his virtues (p. 220).

Perfect truth is not attainable anywhere. We style this Degree that of Perfection; and yet what it teaches is imperfect and defective. Yet we are not to relax in the pursuit of truth, nor contentedly acquiesce in error, it is our duty always to press

forward in the search; for though absolute truth is unattainable, yet the amount of error in our views is capable of progressive and perpetual diminution; and thus Masonry is a continual struggle toward the light (p. 223).

[The Mason] *endeavors rightly to adjust the respective claims of Heaven and earth upon his time and thought, ...* (p. 232).

Believe as you may, my brother; if the Universe is not, to you, without a God, and if man is not like the beast that perishes, but hath an immortal soul, we welcome you among us, to wear, as we wear, with humility, and conscious of your demerits and shortcomings, the title of Grand Elect, Perfect, and Sublime Mason (p. 233).